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S/COND/24/1257: Discharge of Condition 9 and partial Discharge of Condition 2: Planning Application S/OUT/13/1555

Commentary on Supporting Document: Access and Movement

Supporting Document Section 4: Access and Movement has been prepared for the resolution of conditions on the outline planning consent for 'Planning Application S/COND/24/1257: Discharge of Condition 9 and partial Discharge of Condition 2S/OUT/13/1555 - Outline Planning Permission, for a sustainable urban extension to the east of Swindon and north of the A420'.

Below is the commentary from the Swindon Cycle Campaign on that document in order to assist in making the proposed development more cycle (and pedestrian) friendly.

The Strategic Design Code for the development says (page 92) that "6.10 Strategic Cycle and Pedestrian Routes will be designed in accordance with Local Transport Note 1/20 Cycle Infrastructure Design." We do not believe that the Access and Movement document delivers this commitment. We therefore believe that this planning application should be **rejected**, until proposals are made which comply with Local Transport Note 1/20.

Context

Many of the difficulties encountered by cyclist and pedestrians travelling round Swindon are the interruption of routes by facilities for motorised road users. An example is the problems created to the cycle route from Coate Roundabout to the Great Western Hospital by the thoughtless design of road crossings at the Badbury Park development. Neither of those crossings can be easily traversed by cycle. Additionally, pedestrians are herded through the junction by the extensive provision of pedestrian guard rails.

Pedestrian guard rails are excused by highway designers as an aid to prevent pedestrians stepping into the carriageway. What actually happens is that drivers see that pedestrians are corralled and it is therefore safe for them to increase their speed through a junction and for them to have less care for other road users. The outcome of the use of pedestrian guard rails is the increase in vehicle speeds and the further limiting of and discouragement to other road users to pass and repass unhindered. Further, many pedestrians and cyclists follow the less than desirable desire line. Correct initial design following Manual for Streets (MfS) should occur: this does not require use of guard rails in the ways described above.

Landscaping adjacent to footways and cycleways should be set-back sufficiently to allow for growth. New planting adjacent to the bus/cycle facility adjacent to the Waitrose store is too close to the footway/cycleway and will be growing over the facility within a short time. It is usual for S106 Agreements to include a sum for the future maintenance of vegetation. It does not appear that these sums are being spent for their intended purpose.

Comments on the Access and Movement document

This document will refer to paragraph and figures in the Access and Movement document.

Paragraph 4.3 This paragraph refers to Green Bridge being the link for pedestrians and cyclists to the A420. However, the figure below notes that Green Bridge is a 'Proposed 2m Green Bridge Footway'. It is therefore not a suitable link for cyclists.

We would note that the proposed feature appears to be an existing footbridge over the railway with steps.

If this crossing is actually intended for cycle use (which it should), then it needs ramps which are smooth and less steep, and a width of at least 3m. Steps on the crossing are inappropriate as they will severely discourage cycle use.

This feature does give access to the A420. However, this road is not attractive for cyclists and there are no footways. There is no indication in the plans provided that there is intended to be a safe and attractive crossing of the A420 for pedestrians/cyclists to reach the Great Stall East and other development south of the A420. It is therefore presumably expected by the scheme designers that persons wishing to travel between the development and the residential and employment area south of the A420 should do so by motorised mode.

This therefore cannot honestly be described as a 'sustainable urban extension'.

The Swindon Cycle Campaign request that the 'Access and Movement' document be comprehensive for pedestrians and cyclists and reflect their needs. This should include details of how the proposed development is linked to development to the south of the A420. Particularly, the 'Access Point' junctions need to incorporate pedestrian and cycle crossing stages/facilities, which should be explicitly addressed in the 'Access and Movement' document.

Plan page 26 This plan does not show a strategic cycle connection between the development and the existing Swindon cycle network.

This therefore cannot honestly be described as a 'sustainable urban extension'.

The Swindon Cycle Campaign request that the 'Access and Movement' document be comprehensive for pedestrians and cyclists and reflect their needs.

The travel plan approved under application S/OUT/13/1555 (Appendix 7B) includes:

Measure	Responsible Person	Timescale
Pre-occupation Stage		
A fully permeable layout through the site for pedestrians and cyclists reflecting desire lines	Developer	Included with the approved site layout
Parking in line with current guidance	Developer	Included with the approved site layout
On-site streets and junctions designed to the standards outlined in the Department for Transport's Manual for Streets	Developer	Included with the approved site layout
Shared surfaces on residential loop lanes to promote pedestrian movements, creating a 'Home Zone' style street environment	Developer	Included with the approved site layout
Walking and cycling on site linked to existing external routes.	Developer	Included with the approved site layout
Careful street design to restrict vehicular speeds to 20mph or less within home zones	Developer	Included with the approved site layout
Secure and conveniently located cycle storage provision	Developer	Included with the approved site layout

Plan page 27 The legend for the plan on page 27 notes 'Pedestrian & Cycle Access Point (location and number indicative)'. This document therefore does not give comfort that any links for pedestrians and cyclists will be delivered. This is unacceptable in a document which purports to provide details of facilities for all movement types.

Document Section 5: Built Form and Identity gives a substantial amount of landscape details. However, it replicates the plan on page 27 of Access and Movement, including the note reproduced above.

No details of any pedestrian and cycle access points are therefore provided. This is the detailed planning application, yet it is devoid of detail which can be tested at the construction stage.

This therefore cannot honestly be described as a 'sustainable urban extension'.

The Swindon Cycle Campaign request that the 'Access and Movement' document be comprehensive for pedestrians and cyclists and reflect their needs.

Table page 28 Item 8 of this table states that 'The pedestrian, cycle, and bridle routes will be designed as part of the reserved matters landscaping details for the strategic open space and will be provided prior to the occupation of 95% of dwellings within the phase'.

This indicates that this Access and Movement document does not describe access and movement. This is to be determined by landscape details.

Furthermore, the pedestrian and cycle routes will only be provided once nearly all dwellings are occupied. Residents will not therefore be encouraged from their first occupation to travel by non-motorised modes. We cannot imagine that this fits well with any proposed Travel Plan for the development. It certainly does not show any meaningful attempt to encourage the use of non-motorised modes from first occupation.

This therefore cannot honestly be described as a 'sustainable urban extension'.

The Swindon Cycle Campaign request that pedestrians' and cyclists' facilities be available from first occupation. We would also express concern that clause 6.19 of the Strategic Design Code includes "New routes will run alongside new cycle tracks and shared cycle and pedestrian tracks. Allowance will be made for uninterrupted 1m min strip where horses can ride adjacent to the paved surface".

This creates a potentially unsafe situation when horses are overtaken by cyclists in close proximity.

Plan page 29 If the development sequencing on this plan is from 1 to 9, then the shorter routes to Swindon to the west are the last to be constructed. This includes the 3.5m Shared Cycle Track & Walkway shown on page 27. The requirement for residents from the western parcel shown on the plan to travel east before returning west is unlikely to encourage non-motorised modes.
This therefore cannot honestly be described as a 'sustainable urban extension'.
The Swindon Cycle Campaign request that the 'Access and Movement' document be comprehensive for pedestrians and cyclists and reflect their needs, including appropriate sequencing.

Secondary Street Page 30 gives us a table indicating the design criteria.
The design standard is MfS, the Target Speed is 20mph and the carriageway width is 5.5m. Regrettably, these criteria are an oxymoron.
MfS Figure 7.1 shows that a 5.5m carriageway can carry two passing lorries at free flow speeds. In relation to MfS it must be assumed that free flow speeds are 30mph. Therefore, such a wide carriageway will allow cars, indeed may encourage cars, to pass at above 30 miles per hour. The design criteria will therefore not be met with this carriageway width. A 4.8 metre carriageway allows a lorry to pass a car, and is adequate for this residential area, where the only frequent lorry visitor will be the refuse collections and lorries are therefore unlikely to have to pass.
Figure 7.16 of MfS provides us with details of research into vehicle speeds in relation to carriageway width. It shows that increased carriageway width always increases vehicle speeds irrespective of the forward visibility on the road.
Wider carriageways mean higher speeds.
Additionally, as shown in Figure 7.16, greater forward visibility along a road will increase vehicle speeds. The flowing nature of the proposals shown on page 27 will not reduce forward visibility and will not therefore encourage lower vehicle speeds.
Additionally, why would one provide nearly 15% more carriageway width, that is 15% more stone and bituminous material than necessary.
This therefore cannot honestly be described as a 'sustainable urban extension'.
The Swindon Cycle Campaign request that detail on how the design speed is to be met be provided and that provision for cycling is designed in accordance with Local Transport Note 1/20. The use of raised crossings giving priority to pedestrians and cyclists (see figure 10.6 of LTN 1/20) will have the benefit of moderating traffic speeds.

Tertiary Streets The Access and Movement document does not give any details of the junctions between the secondary and the tertiary streets. For pedestrians and cyclists this is an important part of their journey experience.
The design of these junctions within Swindon generally ignores the advice in MfS. For example, the junction between Peglars Way and Semington Strand gives preference to motorised modes; pedestrians and cyclist have to wait for any motor vehicle to pass before crossing. Pedestrians are not provided with

crossing facilities on their desire line, as encouraged at paragraphs 6.3.9 and 6.3.12 of MfS.
Additionally, residential priority junctions in Swindon generally provide large bellmouth radii. These encourage vehicles to turn quickly. Figure 6.3 of MfS shows best and worst practice. Swindon generally follows worst practice in the past and this needs to be changed if sustainable travel is to be encouraged.
Similarly, on the newly built access to the eastern villages development from Commonhead Roundabout, all vehicle accesses, even those serving single dwellings, have large radii and are kerbed, giving priority to motorised users over the pedestrians and cyclists on the shared surface route. Each of these crossings provides a little less incentive to travel by non-motorised modes and signals the priority given by Swindon highway engineers to the various travel modes. Provision for cycling should be designed in accordance with Local Transport Note 1/20, with priority given to cyclists as described in paragraphs 10.5.7 ff.

The carriageway width of 5.0m for tertiary streets will again encourage excess vehicle speed.
Additionally, the straight alignment of many of the tertiary streets will encourage excess vehicle speed without the introduction of traffic calming features such as speed tables and carriageway narrowings.
The Swindon Cycle Campaign request that detail on how the design speed is to be met be provided.

Shared Surface

Section D-D on page 33 purports to show a shared surface route. It does not. The diagram shows a kerb-type feature between a purported 5m shared surface and a 2m strip.
Drivers will read this kerb-type feature as being a delineation between a carriageway and a footway, as is indeed shown by the users on the section.
This is not a shared surface road, it is a typical residential street with a reduced kerb height.
Ash Close in Peatmoor is an example of the Swindon pseudo shared surface road. Newman View in Tadpole Farm on the opposite side of Common Platt is a real shared surface road. Newman View is in Wiltshire, Ash Close is in Swindon.
Provision for cycling should be designed in accordance with Local Transport Note 1/20, especially section 6.5.

Vehicle Parking

Paragraph 4.38 and the accompanying photograph describe on-plot parking behind footways and verges. The experience at Badbury Park and increasingly at Tadpole Farm is that residents do not park on-plot. Instead they park on-street perpendicular to the carriageway notionally within the verge width. Usually the verge width is less than a car length and cars therefore block the footway/cycleway.
If a verge feature is to be used on this development, verges need to be at least 6 metre wide or absent.

The document does not indicate how the design of streets will discourage on-footway parking. If this is to be discouraged by the use of bollards, then the

width of the bollard should not intrude into the width of the footway. It should ideally be taken from the width of the carriageway (as described above). Whatever the means adopted, on-footway parking must be discouraged as it dissuades non-motorised modes. It would be ironic for Swindon to be seeking Traffic Regulation Orders to ban footway parking in one part of the Borough whilst building new development which did not discourage on-footway parking in another part of the Borough.
The Swindon Cycle Campaign request that detail on how footway parking is to be prevented be provided.
Provision for cycling should be designed in accordance with Local Transport Note 1/20, especially section 7.

Cycle Parking Paragraph 4.47 tells us that 'Residents will be allowed to store their bicycles conveniently'. This is so vague as to be meaningless. Who will allow them to do this? How will they know that they have been allowed? Will cycle storage be secure? What standard will be used when designing and providing cycle parking?

Summary

It is clear that the design of the development is not a sustainable design. Many of the features proposed discourage sustainable travel on foot or by bicycle. Excess vehicle speeds on the roads are certain to occur and the stated design speed will not be met.
Many of the detailed design features which aid pedestrian and cycle movement are not addressed in the document, and the typical practice in Swindon will generally encourage motorised modes and discourage sustainable travel. There is no indication that this development will be any different from those recently constructed in Swindon.

The scheme delivered by this design manual will not be sustainable. Now is the time for planning officers to require a better document which will deliver sustainable travel on foot and by bicycle. If this is not addressed now, then it can be guaranteed that at the S278 stage, highways officers will permit or even encourage a design which fails the tests in Manual for Streets and fails pedestrians and cyclists. They have repeatedly done so before.

The 'Access and Movement' document is wholly inadequate. It needs to be comprehensively rewritten to reflect best practice in both Manual for Streets and Local Transport Note 1/20 and learn from the poor practice displayed in recently constructed residential development in Swindon. It needs to actually reflect the chosen design speed.

A new consultation period should be started once a comprehensive document is provided. Prior to that, highway development control officers should be requesting refusal of the planning application, as it does not meet the needs of pedestrians and cyclists in a sustainable urban extension.

We hope that the spirit of these comments is accepted, and that planning and highways officers will be able to use them to help determine future planning applications.

Dick Millard
Chair